

The Architecture of Emptiness and Consciousness

A unified study guide to Śūnyavāda, Vijñānavāda, and Svatantra-Vijñānavāda — how Mahāyāna Buddhist philosophy moves from the destruction of all categories to a logic of the momentary particular

Based on C.D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, Chapters 6–8. This guide does not summarize each chapter in turn; it re-organizes the material around the single question that drives all three schools — what, if anything, survives Buddhist analysis as real, and how do we know it? — and shows exactly where each school inherits, revises, or rejects its predecessor's answer.

How to Read This Guide

Part 0 lays out the shared grammar every school presupposes (Two Truths, the tetralemma, the intellect/experience split) so that it need not be re-explained three times. Parts 1–3 treat each school in turn, but each ends with a “what this leaves unsolved” paragraph that hands you directly into the next school's motivation. Part 4 is pure comparison. Part 5 collects the tradition's internal quarrels — the places philosophers within Buddhism disagreed with each other, which is where exam and discussion questions usually live. Part 6 is a merged, cross-referenced glossary. Part 7 is a one-page recall sheet.

ASVAGHOSA		
Tathata beyond all categories		
latent seeds in early		
Mahayana Sutras		
v		
+-----+		
	SUNYAVADA	Ch.6, Nagarjuna

	All dharmas are	
	SUNYA: relative +	
	empty of own-	
	being. Method:	
	DESTRUCTIVE	
	DIALECTIC (tetra-	
	lemma) applied to	
	causation, motion,	
	self, time,	
	Nirvana, Buddha.	
	Reality is	
	INDESCRIBABLE --	
	beyond Sunya and	
	Asunya alike.	

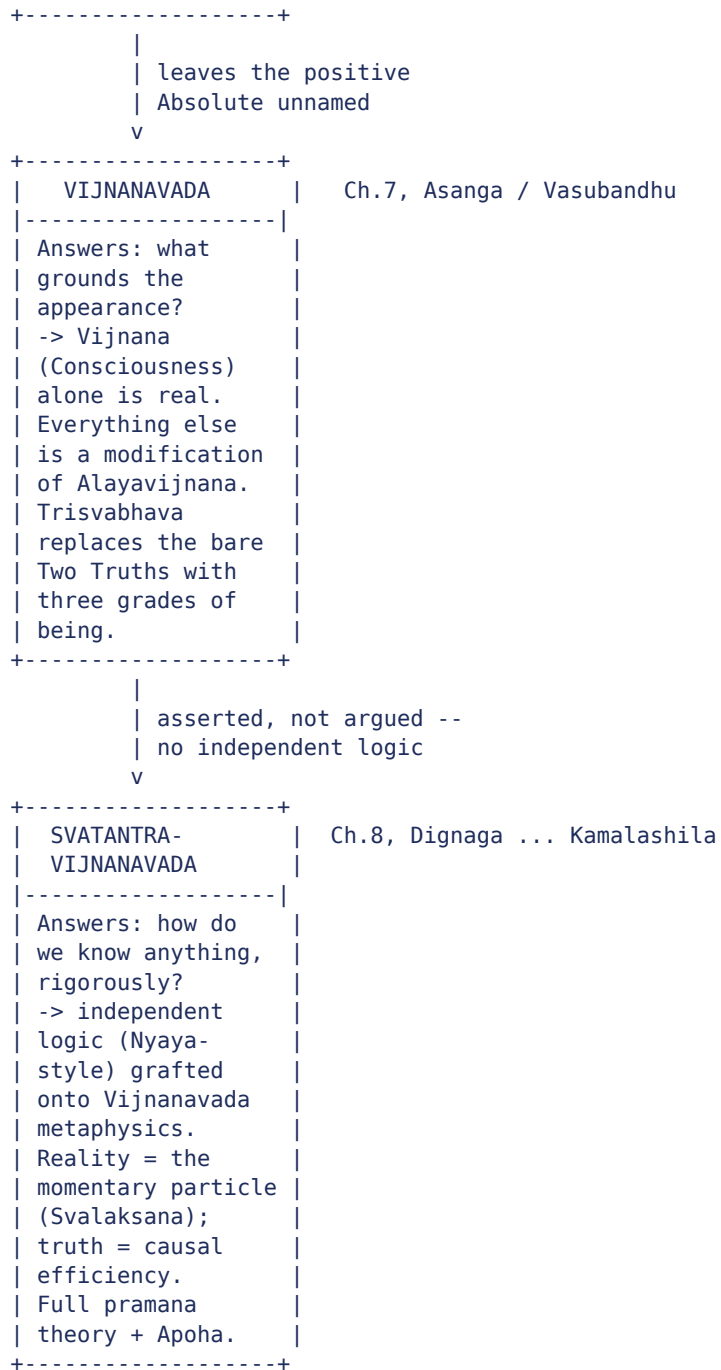


Figure 1. The three schools are not independent essays — each is the next generation's answer to a gap its predecessor left open. Read the arrows as “inherits the problem, changes the tool.”

PART 0 · The Shared Grammar of Mahāyāna Philosophy

Before separating the schools, notice what they never argue about. All three accept a common toolkit inherited ultimately from Aśvaghōṣa, the shadowy proto-Mahāyāna figure whose authorship of the Mahāyānashraddhotpāda-śāstra is disputed but whose ideas Sharma treats as the taproot of the entire tradition. Aśvaghōṣa's one move — that Reality (Tathatā, “Suchness”) is beyond all categories the intellect can form — branches in two directions: call it Śūnya (empty of categories) and you get Śūnyavāda; call it Consciousness (Bodhi, Ālayavijñāna) and you get Vijñānavāda. Keep this bifurcation in view; it explains why the two schools sound so different while arguing, at bottom, about the same Reality.

0.1 The Two Truths (Saṃvṛti / Paramārtha)

Every school distinguishes a conventional/empirical standpoint (Saṃvṛti or Vyavahāra — “covering,” a practical compromise that is not, in the end, true) from an absolute standpoint (Paramārtha — reached only through direct, non-discursive spiritual experience, prajñā). The relation between them is never one of simple negation. The standard image, given almost identically in the Prajñā-pāramitā literature: if a ship capsizes, those who cling to a plank — however flimsy — reach shore, while those who refuse any support drown. The phenomenal is the plank: not the destination, but the only means of reaching it. This is why none of these schools count as nihilism, whatever their critics said at the time.

0.2 The Catuṣkoṭi (Tetralemma)

The single most important piece of technical apparatus in this entire tradition. Ordinary logic offers two options for any predicate P: “P” or “not-P.” Buddhist dialectic insists intellect actually generates four options for any question about ultimate reality:

- (1) it is P (existence / affirmation)
- (2) it is not-P (non-existence / negation)
- (3) it is both P and not-P
- (4) it is neither P nor not-P

The destructive dialectic's characteristic move, used by Nāgārjuna against causation, motion, the self, Nirvāṇa, and even the Buddha alike, and later reused by Dharmakīrti against permanent causes of every description, is to show that all four horns fail for a given category — which is taken to prove that the category is merely relative (empirically workable, ultimately unreal), not that nothing at all is happening. Keep this distinction — relative-and-therefore-not-ultimate versus simply nothing — in mind throughout; conflating them is the single most common misreading of this material, and Sharma repeatedly stops to correct it.

0.3 Intellect (Tarka) versus Spiritual Experience (Prajñā)

All three schools treat ordinary conceptual thought as inherently dualistic, relational, and therefore incapable of delivering the Real, while treating direct, non-dual realization as the only route to it. The Laṅkāvatāra's imagery — those “entangled in intellect” are “worse than dogs,” fools stuck in language “like elephants in deep mud” — is not decoration; it states the

tradition's central epistemic claim, that discursive knowledge and liberating knowledge are different in kind, not just in degree. Where the schools differ is over how much residual work discursive reason (logic, argument, inference) can still do on the way there — and that disagreement is precisely what produces the Prāsaṅgika/Svātantrika split inside Śūnyavāda and the entire logical program of Chapter 8.

0.4 Nairātmya (No-Self) Extended: Two Kinds of Ignorance

Early Buddhism denied only the reality of the personal self (pudgala-nairātmya). Every school treated in this guide extends the denial to phenomena/elements themselves (dharma-nairātmya) — this is precisely the “revolution” from Hīnayāna to Mahāyāna that the Śūnyavāda notes describe. Correspondingly, later Yogācāra texts (Sthiramati's commentary, Śāntideva) name two obscurations that must be removed:

- Kleśāvaraṇa — the screen of defilement: ignorance/passion covering the self, producing suffering.
- Jñeyāvaraṇa — the screen of the knowable: the intellect's compulsion to reify objects, covering the true nature of phenomena.

This pair recurs verbatim in Śāntideva (Ch.6) and in Sthiramati's gloss on Vasubandhu's Triṃśikā (Ch.7) — a good example of vocabulary that looks school-specific but is actually shared property.

0.5 Momentariness (Kṣaṇikavāda): One Doctrine, Three Different Reaches

All three schools affirm that ordinary phenomena are momentary, but they disagree sharply about how far the doctrine reaches — and this single variable is one of the cleanest ways to tell the schools apart on an exam:

School	What is momentary	What (if anything) is exempt
Śūnyavāda	All phenomenal dharmas, causation, motion, the five skandhas, time itself.	The Absolute (Prapañcha-śūnya Tattva) — beyond momentary and permanent alike, since both are intellectual categories.
Vijñānavāda	All phenomena, including the empirical ego and the six vijñānas ("waves"); explicitly a river/lamp-flame analogy.	Pure Consciousness (Vijñaptimātra) is eternal, immortal, permanent (Sthiramati insists on true nityatva, not mere relative permanence).
Svatantra-Vijñānavāda	Everything without exception — this is the doctrine's maximal extension. Existence just is causal efficiency, and efficiency just is momentariness.	Nothing empirically nameable; the Svalakṣaṇa itself is momentary. Ultimate Reality (Pure Consciousness, per Śāntarakṣita) is admitted but is not itself an object the logical apparatus needs to secure.

Table 1. Notice the ratchet: momentariness starts as a claim about causation and the self, and ends (in Chapter 8) as a claim about literally everything that can be named — the most aggressive nominalism of the three schools.

PART 1 · Śūnyavāda — Emptiness as Method, Not Metaphysics

1.1 Why It Arises: Systematizing, Not Inventing

Sharma is emphatic on a point students often miss: Nāgārjuna did not found Śūnyavāda. The doctrine was already scattered through pre-Aśvaghoṣa Mahāyāna sūtras — the Saddharma-puṇḍarīka, the Prajñā-pāramitā literature, the Laṅkāvatāra. Nāgārjuna's achievement was to seize these scattered threads and weave them into one thoroughly consistent dialectical system in the Mādhyamika-Kārikā. His followers accordingly call themselves Mādhyamikas — “Middle-Path” philosophers — not Śūnyavādins; the label “Śūnyavāda” is a description of their conclusion, not their self-image.

1.2 The Four-Part Meaning of Śūnya (the Concept You Must Get Exactly Right)

The single most consequential terminological correction in the whole tradition. 'Śūnya' does not mean “nothing” or “empty void” — that reading, which produced centuries of the (mistaken) charge that Mādhyamikas are nihilists, misses a deliberate double meaning:

- Indescribable (avācya) — Reality is beyond all four horns of the catuṣkoṭi: neither existent, non-existent, both, nor neither.
- Relativity (pratītyasamutpāda) — empirically, Śūnya names Saṃsāra/phenomena: whatever is dependently originated is svabhāva-śūnya, devoid of an own-nature, the way borrowed wealth is not real capital — but not therefore absolutely unreal.
- Reality (tattva) — absolutely, Śūnya names release from plurality, i.e. Nirvāṇa itself: the Non-dual Whole in which all distinctions merge (prapañcha-śūnya).
- Both at once — Śūnya means Relativity and Reality, Saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa, simultaneously. Appearances are svabhāva-śūnya; the Real is prapañcha-śūnya. Even Stcherbatsky's famous rendering of Śūnya as simply “Relativity” captures only one of the two aspects and is, on Sharma's reading, an incomplete translation.

This is why Śūnyavādins insist they occupy a genuine middle path: to say the world exists absolutely is the eternalist error; to say it does not exist even phenomenally is the nihilist error. Correct doctrine affirms phenomenal Saṃsāra and denies its ultimacy in the same breath.

1.3 The Destructive Dialectic: One Engine, Many Targets

Rather than list each refutation Nāgārjuna performs as a separate argument, it is far more useful to see that a single logical engine — the four-fold refutation of origination — is run repeatedly against a series of targets. The engine, stated once:

No-Origination (Anutpāda). A thing cannot arise (a) out of itself — because if the effect already exists in the cause it needs no further production, and if it does not exist there, nothing can produce it, any more than a hare's horn; (b) out of another — if it cannot arise from itself, a fortiori not from what is other than itself; (c) out of both — self-contradictory,

like light and darkness coexisting; (d) at random, uncaused — obviously impossible. Since none of the four alternatives survives, origination itself is only an appearance.

Nāgārjuna and Chandrakīrti then simply feed different subjects through this same engine (occasionally supplemented by parallel trilemma/dilemma structures — e.g. the “already-traversed / not-yet-traversed / neither” analysis of a path used to refute motion):

Target	How the engine applies
Causation (4 pratyayas)	Each of Hīnayāna's four conditions (hetu, ālambana, samanantara, adhipati) fails the same test: a causeless cause is a hare's horn; if the effect pre-exists in the cause, milk should already be curd.
Motion	A path already-traversed needs no traversing; a not-yet-traversed path is not yet a path; a mover cannot move (already in motion) and a non-mover cannot move either — so 'moving' names nothing real.
The five skandhas / matter	Matter existent needs no cause; matter non-existent cannot be caused (like a hare's horn); uncaused matter is impossible — so rūpa, and by the same pattern vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna, are all unreal.
The self (ego)	Neither identical with the skandhas (then it would share their birth-and-death) nor different from them (then it would be unknowable) — so the 'I' has no independent status.
Time / the universe	Beginningless and endless by Buddha's own teaching, yet logic says what has no beginning and no end cannot have a middle either — so past/present/future collapse as relative.
Nirvāṇa itself	Cannot be existence (then subject to birth-death like other saṃskṛta dharmas), non-existence (dependent for meaning on existence), both (self-contradictory) or neither (unconceivable) — so even Nirvāṇa fails all four horns.
The Buddha (Tathāgata)	Neither identical with nor different from the skandhas; cannot be said to exist, not-exist, both or neither after Nirvāṇa — the Buddha too is Śūnya.

Table 2. Once you see the engine, you no longer need to memorize seven separate arguments — you need to memorize one argument-pattern and seven applications of it. This is also how Nāgārjuna generates the fourteen classical antinomies (finite/infinite world, eternal/non-eternal world, Tathāgata's post-mortem status, identity of matter and mind) that Buddha himself answered only by silence.

1.4 The Constructive Side: Why This Is Not Nihilism

Sharma stresses, almost as a refrain, that the Mādhyamika is not a sceptic who doubts for its own sake. Three moves keep the destructive dialectic from collapsing into nihilism:

- Absolute negation is impossible — it necessarily presupposes an affirmation to negate. A dreamer cannot condemn his dream from inside the dream.
- The two-standpoint structure is retained: from Saṃvṛti, phenomena are workable and real; only from Paramārtha are they empty. Intellect is not annihilated, only transcended — 'if we dispense with finite enlightenment, we cannot conceive of true enlightenment' (Aśvaghoṣa).

- The practical path is fully elaborated: four Meditations (dhyānas), three Samādhis (Śūnyatā / Animitta / Apraṇihita), and ten Bodhisattva stages (bhūmis) — a complete soteriology, not a bare logical remainder.

The most quotable image in the whole chapter belongs here: Śūnyatā is compared to a strong purgative — it must clear out every false view, but if the purgative itself does not also leave the system (i.e., if Śūnyatā is grasped as one more category of intellect), the cure has failed and the patient is worse off, “like a snake carelessly caught, it will bite.” Śūnyatā rightly understood is not a further thesis; it is itself Nirvāṇa.

1.5 Meta-Level Defense: The Vighraha-Vyāvarttani

An obvious objection: if all arguments are ultimately empty, doesn't the Śūnyavādin's own argument for emptiness refute itself? Nāgārjuna's answer, restated compactly: we have no thesis of our own. We do not claim “this argument is true while all others are false” — we claim all arguments, including this one, are ultimately unreal, while remaining perfectly usable at the empirical level (the phenomenal cannot be condemned by its own logic). And since a pramāṇa (means of valid cognition) cannot establish its own validity without infinite regress — a father cannot be begotten by his own son — no opponent's demand for a positive proof of Śūnyatā can be met on its own terms either, because that demand presupposes an unearned confidence in pramāṇas generally.

1.6 The First Fork: Prāsaṅgika vs. Svātantrika

Precisely because logic's status is left delicate by Nāgārjuna's self-defense, Mādhyamikas split into two readings of how much positive work reasoning can do:

Sub-school	Position on logic
Prāsaṅgika (Buddhapālita, Chandrakīrti)	Logic is purely negative — a tool to expose an opponent's self-contradiction, never a positive proof of one's own thesis. 'Our words are not policemen; they cannot arrest us.'
Svātantrika (Bhāvaviveka, Diñnāga)	Logic can be used constructively — independent syllogisms (svatantra-anumāna) can positively establish Śūnyatā, not merely demolish opponents.

This is the seam along which the whole tradition eventually splits into Chapter 8's school. Note the name: Svatantra-Vijñānavāda takes its “Svatantra” (independent-reasoning) label directly from this fork — it is, in effect, the Svātantrika impulse pursued to its logical (and metaphysical) limit, fused with Yogācāra idealism.

1.7 What Śūnyavāda Leaves Open

Śūnyavāda tells you, exhaustively, what is not ultimately real, and it gestures at an Absolute “where all plurality is merged” — but it says remarkably little, positively, about what is doing the appearing. Aśvaghōṣa's Tathatā can be named Bodhi, Prajñā, or Ālayavijñāna, but Śūnyavāda proper does not build out that identification. Nor does it explain, mechanistically, how one appearance differs from another (why a dream differs from waking, why one moment gives rise to the next) if all such differences are merely conventional. Vijñānavāda takes

exactly this gap as its starting point: it accepts the entire critique of external objects, the self, and causation, but insists the Absolute pointed to at the end of the dialectic has a nameable, positive character — Consciousness — and sets out to explain the mechanics of appearance in full.

PART 2 · Vijñānavāda — Consciousness as the Only Reality

2.1 The Move: From “Empty” to “Consciousness-Only”

Vijñānavāda (also Yogācāra, after its emphasis on yogic practice as the route to bodhi) does not reopen the destructive dialectic — it accepts Śūnyavāda's conclusion that external objects, causation, and the empirical ego are unreal, and then answers the question Śūnyavāda left underspecified: unreal relative to what? Its answer is blunt: relative to Consciousness (Vijñāna), which alone is real. Vijñaptimātra — “Consciousness-only” — is the school's central thesis: all three worlds (of Matter, Form, and No-form) are the product of discrimination (vikalpa); no object exists outside thought.

Sharma insists — against a “generally believed” caricature — that this is not crude subjectivism. It is not the claim that the individual momentary mind conjures up objects at will; it is the claim that the subject/object distinction itself occurs within one underlying Consciousness, which therefore transcends both terms of the distinction. The external world's objectivity is not denied — objects genuinely appear as objects — only its independence outside Consciousness is denied.

2.2 The Ālaya: Two Different Doctrines Wearing One Name

This is the single most important discrimination to hold onto in Chapter 7, and the exam-question most likely to reward precision. The term Ālayavijñāna (“Store-house Consciousness”) is used in two incompatible ways by two different strata of the same school:

	Laṅkāvatāra's Ālaya	Vasubandhu's Ālaya
Ontological status	Identical with Tathāgatagarbha / Pure Chitta — the Absolute itself.	A phenomenal manifestation of Pure Consciousness (Vijñaptimātra); one station in a threefold modification, not the Absolute itself.
Duration	Permanent, immortal, never-changing (contrary to the popular belief that Ālaya is a flux).	A continually changing stream (vartate srotasaughavat) — ‘like a river’; ceases the instant Buddhahood (Arhatship) is attained.
Relation to individual vijñānas	Transcends them; they are its waves (neither identical nor different from the ocean).	Contains ‘seeds’ (bīja) of all phenomena; the six vijñānas are literally its waves (taraṅgāṇām yathā jale).
Technical status	Beyond production/destruction, beyond plurality; realized only by nirābhāsa-prajñā.	Santati-nitya — relatively permanent (a continuant), not kūṭastha-nitya (absolutely permanent).

Table 3. Sharma's own resolution: behind Vasubandhu's changing, phenomenal Ālaya stands the truly permanent Vijñaptimātra (Pure Consciousness) — so the Laṅkāvatāra's ‘permanent Ālaya’ and Vasubandhu's ‘Vijñaptimātra’ are the same entity described at the deepest level; Vasubandhu's own ‘Ālayavijñāna’ is a more restricted, phenomenal-stream sense of the same word. Confusing the two levels is exactly the mistake Sharma is at pains to prevent.

2.3 Trisvabhāva: Refining the Two Truths into Three

Where Śūnyavāda worked with a two-term distinction (Saṃvṛti/Paramārtha), Vijñānavāda subdivides the conventional side into two, giving a three-level ontology (Trisvabhāva) that maps directly onto — and sharpens — Śūnyavāda's categories:

Level	Śūnyavāda equivalent	Nature	Example
Parikalpita (Imaginary)	(a sub-case of Saṃvṛti)	Purely superimposed, absolutely unreal (atyanta-śūnya) — mere name.	Hare's horn, sky-flower, the perceived subject-object duality itself.
Paratantra (Relative)	Saṃvṛti / Pratītya samutpāda	Dependent on causes and conditions; an appearance, not nothing; the immanent Ālaya is its support.	The stream of dependently-arisen phenomena, error (bhrānti) rather than illusion from nowhere.
Pariniṣpanna (Absolute)	Paramārtha / Prapañcha-śūnya Tattva	Absolutely real, grasped only by direct spiritual experience; devoid of thought-constructions yet exists independently.	Tathatā, Tathāgatagarbha, Āryajñāna — Pure Consciousness itself.

All three svabhāvas are called Nissvabhāva (“devoid of own-nature”) — but, crucially, in three different senses: Parikalpita is nissvabhāva because it is simply unreal; Paratantra because it has no independent existence though it exists as appearance; Pariniṣpanna because it cannot be grasped by any category of intellect, though it exists independently and can be realized directly. This triple sense is Vijñānavāda's answer to anyone who thought 'nissvabhāva' meant the same flavor of unreality throughout Buddhism.

2.4 Vasubandhu's Argument Against External Objects

The Viṃśatikā gives Vijñānavāda something Śūnyavāda's dialectic never bothered to supply: a direct epistemological argument that no object exists outside thought, built by defusing four realist objections one at a time.

Realist objection	Vasubandhu's reply
Spatial determination — an object appears in one place, not everywhere.	So do dream-objects: a dream-city appears in one place within the dream, with no external object required.
Temporal determination — an object appears at one time, not always.	Likewise true of dreams; temporal specificity does not require an external anchor.
Intersubjective agreement — many people see the same object.	The denizens of hell all see the same river of pus without any external object — a shared karmic vāsanā (impression) in consciousness suffices; even the infernal guards are unreal, since they alone do not suffer hell's torments.

Realist objection	Vasubandhu's reply
Fruitful/causal activity — real objects (unlike dream-objects) can satisfy hunger, cause real effects.	A dream-tiger's roar produces real fear and wakes the sleeper; an erotic dream has real physical consequences — causal efficacy does not require external objects either.

The dream analogy is then generalized into the school's central epistemic claim: just as a dreamer cannot, from within the dream, tell that the dream-objects are unreal, so too the unenlightened cannot, from within waking ignorance, recognize that the waking world is equally a construction of consciousness. Only 'awakening' — bodhi — reveals this from outside.

2.5 Abhūtaparikalpa: Vijñānavāda's Explicit Defense Against the Nihilism Charge

Vijñānavāda is, in Sharma's assessment, more careful than Śūnyavāda in explicitly blocking a nihilistic misreading — he calls this “one of the chief merits” of the school, a difference of degree, not kind, from Śūnyavāda's own (more implicit) defense. The key concept, Abhūtaparikalpa (“construction of the unreal”), is applied at all three levels of Trisvabhāva simultaneously: as the Absolute, it is the real ground upon which superimposition occurs without itself superimposing anything; as the Relative (Paratantra), it is the Ālaya's self-creative energy actually generating the phenomenal subject-object world; as the Imaginary (Parikalpita), it is that superimposed duality itself. The rule that keeps this from collapsing into either eternalism or nihilism: only the superimposed can be negated; the ground of superimposition is real. Śūnyatā is never absolute negation — it is always the negation of something in something.

2.6 What Vijñānavāda Leaves Open

Vijñānavāda gives Śūnyavāda's Absolute a name and a mechanism, but it does this largely through scriptural exegesis, meditative testimony, and metaphysical assertion — Asaṅga's critique of tarka (intellect) explicitly downgrades ordinary reasoning as merely provisional, partial, and phenomenal. What it does not supply is a rigorous, freestanding epistemology: a worked-out account of what perception and inference actually are, how a syllogism should be validly built, or why the Naiyāyika and Mīmāṃsaka opponents (who by this period had a sophisticated logic of their own) should concede the argument on their own terms rather than Buddhism's. This is exactly the gap Dinnāga's Svatantra-Vijñānavāda closes: same idealist metaphysics, married now to an independent, technically rigorous logic (pramāṇa-śāstra) capable of meeting Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā on their own logical ground.

PART 3 · Svatantra-Vijñānavāda — The Logical Turn

3.1 Program: Idealism Plus Independent Logic Plus Critical Realism

The school's three names — Svatantra-Vijñānavāda, Svatantra-Yogācāra, Sautrāntika-Yogācāra — advertise its triple parentage: it keeps Vijñānavāda's metaphysics (Consciousness alone is real), adds independent logical argument in its own defense (Svatantra, resolving the fork opened in §1.6 in the constructive direction), and grafts on the epistemological rigour of Sautrāntika Critical Realism (careful analysis of perception and inference as two genuinely distinct sources of knowledge). Sharma's own label for the result: the Logical School of Buddhism. Its lineage runs Diñnāga (founder; disciple of Vasubandhu himself) → Dharmakīrti (full elaboration) → Śāntarakṣita (near-perfection; Tattva-saṅgraha) → Kamalashīla (commentary; the last great Buddhist scholar in India, forced into Tibetan exile along with Śāntarakṣita as Brāhmanical philosophy reasserted itself). With Kamalashīla, Sharma notes, Buddhist philosophy as a living Indian tradition effectively ends.

Sharma adds a sharp critical aside worth remembering: although Diñnāga, Dharmakīrti, and Śāntarakṣita all pay lip-service to following Vasubandhu, they actually demote his metaphysics — Vasubandhu's permanent Vijñaptimātra quietly disappears, replaced by a momentary Vijñāna or a unique momentary particular (Svalakṣaṇa). The Ālayavijñāna and Vijñaptimātra of Chapter 7 are simply not carried forward as working concepts in Chapter 8's technical apparatus.

3.2 The New Criterion of Reality: Causal Efficiency

The school's defining equation, stated by Dharmakīrti: arthakriyā-sāmarthya-lakṣaṇam paramārtha-sat — “that whose mark is the capacity for effective/successful activity is ultimately existent.” This yields a chain of identifications that looks paradoxical until unpacked:

- Existence = efficiency; efficiency = change (only what changes can act, hence only what changes is efficient).
- The changeless is therefore inefficient, and the inefficient is unreal — this is a direct inversion of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, where permanent substances underlie change.
- The ultimately real is thus the momentary particular, the Svalakṣaṇa — the bare 'this,' the 'here-now,' indescribable because it is shorn of every conceptual (hence generalizing, hence falsifying) overlay.

The apparent contradiction — reality is motion, yet a strictly momentary thing has no time in which to move — is dissolved rather than avoided: motion is only a series of immobilities, the way a lamp's 'single flame' is really a rapid succession of distinct flames, or a river's 'sameness' is really fresh water arriving every instant. Things do not have motion; things simply are motion, understood as a sequence of point-instants.

3.3 Causality Without Production

Consistently with the momentariness thesis, causality can no longer mean one thing producing another (production takes time; momentary things have none). It is redefined as functional interdependence: the cause merely precedes, the effect merely follows; “this being, that arises” (ānantarya-niyama, invariable antecedence) replaces any thicker notion of production. All dharmas are, in a phrase Sharma quotes directly, nirvyāpārāḥ akiñchit-karāḥ — inactive and forceless — and yet reality just is efficiency, because there is, on this view, no efficiency floating free of bare existence in the first place (sattaiva vyāpṛtiḥ, “existence itself is the operation”). Notice the structural continuity with Nāgārjuna's Anutpāda (§1.3): both traditions deny that anything is really produced; Śūnyavāda concludes causation is therefore merely relative/empty, while the Logical school concludes causation is real but must be redescribed as bare succession rather than production.

3.4 Momentariness Without a Cause for Destruction

Dharmakīrti's sharpest and most counter-intuitive claim: annihilation requires no cause, because “destruction” of a momentary thing doesn't name the elimination of a positive entity — it just names the fact that the thing was momentary in the first place. Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla refine this into two kinds of destruction: Kṣaṇa-sthiti-dharma-rūpa-vināśa (the transcendental fact of momentary-ness, whose only 'cause' is the entity's own production) versus Dhvaṃsa-rūpa-nāśa (ordinary empirical “disruption,” which is causeless and asserts nothing positive at all — it simply registers that the thing is no longer there).

A permanent entity, by contrast, is convicted of a dilemma: it should produce all its effects simultaneously, since an efficient cause once present has no reason to delay; and if it needs 'accessories' to produce effects successively, those accessories either modify the permanent cause (in which case the modification, not the permanent thing, is the real cause) or act independently (in which case the supposed cause is doing no work). This dilemma is later run systematically against Prakṛti, Īśvara, and Brahman — see §3.6.

3.5 Pramāṇa Theory: Two Sources of Knowledge, Matched to Two Kinds of Object

The school's epistemological signature: exactly two valid Pramāṇas, corresponding one-to-one to the two kinds of Prameya (knowable):

Pramāṇa	Object grasped	Character
Perception (Pratyakṣa)	Svalakṣaṇa — the unique momentary particular	Direct, devoid of all thought-determination (Dīnnāga: kalpanāpoḍha); Dharmakīrti adds 'non-illusive' (abhrānta) to exclude sense-errors like the double-moon.

Pramāṇa	Object grasped	Character
Inference (Anumāna)	Sāmānyalakṣaṇa — the universal/general character	Indirect; built on Vyāpti (invariable concomitance) via a valid middle term; Dīnnāga compresses Nyāya's five-membered syllogism to two members (Example-with-Rule, and Application).

Every other candidate pramāṇa the Naiyāyikas and Mīmāṃsakas propose — verbal testimony, analogy, implication, negation — is argued to reduce to perception or inference, or to be no pramāṇa at all. This includes a sustained assault on Vedic authority: an unauthored, eternal Veda cannot mean anything (only persons can mean), and inference/perception, being directly testable, must always outrank scriptural claim where the two conflict.

3.6 Apoha: Meaning as Pure Negation

If Reality is always a bare particular, ordinary words (which denote universals — “cow-ness” applying to many cows) cannot touch it at all; Dīnnāga's radical conclusion is that words work only negatively. “Cow” does not positively denote any real universal; it means, functionally, “not-non-cow.” Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla refine this against the obvious objection (doesn't “not-non-cow” smuggle back in a positive cow-universal?) by distinguishing relative negation (exclusion, paryudāsa) from absolute negation (denial, niṣedha): a word directly produces only a subjective “reflection” (pratibimbaka) of similarity across otherwise wholly dissimilar particulars, and the further “exclusion of other objects” follows only by implication. Words, in short, cognize their own internal reflections, never external objects directly — meaning is a construction laid over particulars that are, in themselves, neither unified nor diversified.

3.7 The Critique Machine, Redirected at Brahmanical Metaphysics

Chapter 8 essentially re-runs Chapter 6's destructive dialectic (§1.3), but re-tooled: instead of the catuṣkoṭi, its favored weapons are the simultaneity dilemma (a permanent cause must produce all effects at once) and the infinite-regress dilemma (any further explainer needs its own explainer). One underlying strategy, several targets:

Target	Core objection
Substance (Dravya) / the Six Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika Categories	We perceive only qualities, never any substance underlying them; a lump of ten gold pieces weighs the same as the ten separate pieces, so the 'whole' adds nothing real over its parts.
Prakṛti (Sāṅkhya's Primordial Matter)	The five classical arguments for Satkāryavāda (effect pre-exists in cause) can be reversed point-for-point against it; an eternal Prakṛti, like any permanent cause, cannot explain successive, non-simultaneous creation.

Target	Core objection
Īśvara (God as Creator)	An eternal, changeless God cannot be a cause (causes must be momentary and efficient); if God needs accessories to create in time, either they are the real causes or God is superfluous; infinite regress looms (what caused God?); and theodicy fails (a compassionate, free creator would not permit misery).
Brahman (Advaita)	An undifferentiated, permanent Consciousness cannot itself produce any cognition (cognition is successive); if Brahman just is Consciousness, bondage/Ignorance become impossible; if Ignorance is Brahman's own nature, liberation becomes impossible.
Ātman (five versions: Upaniṣadic, Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, Mīmāṃsā/Kumārila, Sāṅkhya, Jaina)	Each version is refuted on its own terms — e.g. Kumārila's snake-simile (self stays one, though 'coiled' or 'straight') is turned around: a snake changes shape only because it, too, is momentary; a truly permanent self could never coil.

Table 4. The refutation of Ātman is the most elaborate single argument in the chapter (five sub-targets), but every version reduces to the same complaint: any philosophy that posits a permanent substrate behind changing experience cannot explain how that substrate ever does anything, including producing the very diversity of experience it is invoked to explain.

3.8 Pure Consciousness Reintroduced — and Complicated

Having spent most of the chapter defending a nominalist ontology of bare momentary particulars, Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla still affirm, as Nirākāra-Vijñānavādins (“upholders of Formless Consciousness”), that ultimate Reality is Pure, non-dual Consciousness transcending subject-object duality — explicitly crediting Vasubandhu's Vijñaptimātratā-siddhi and Diṇnāga's Ālambana-parīkṣā as their authority here. The tension this creates with the school's own momentariness doctrine (§3.2–3.4) is real and is, in effect, the same tension that separates the phenomenal Ālaya from the eternal Vijñaptimātra in Chapter 7 (Table 3) — the Logical school inherits, rather than resolves, that fault line. See §5 for exactly where this becomes an open internal dispute.

PART 4 · The Three Schools, Side by Side

4.1 Master Comparison Table

Question	Śūnyavāda	Vijñānavāda	Svatantra-Vijñānavāda
What is ultimately real?	The Non-dual Absolute (Tattva) — beyond Śūnya and Aśūnya alike; positively unnameable.	Pure Consciousness (Vijñaptimātra) — permanent, self-luminous, non-dual.	Officially: Pure Consciousness (per Śāntarakṣita). Operationally: the momentary particular (Svalakṣaṇa), defined by causal efficiency.
Status of external objects	Relative/dependently-originated, hence svabhāva-śūnya; not absolutely non-existent.	Do not exist outside thought; are the 'knowable-aspect' (grāhya) of Consciousness.	Same conclusion as Vijñānavāda, argued via Dīnāga's Ālambana-parīkṣā and Dharmakīrti's relative-existence analysis.
Status of the self	Neither identical with nor different from the skandhas; unreal as an independent entity.	The empirical ego is unreal (product of Ignorance); the Universal/Pure Self is the one Reality.	Same denial extended into a full polemic against five Brahmanical versions of Ātman (§3.7).
Reach of momentariness	Applies to all phenomena; the Absolute is beyond momentary/permanent altogether.	Applies to all phenomena including the Ālaya-as-stream; Vijñaptimātra itself is truly eternal.	Applies to literally everything nameable — the maximal extension (Table 1).
Status of logic/intellect	Split: Prāsaṅgika treats logic as purely negative; Svātantrika allows independent positive proof.	Downgraded: tarka is provisional, partial, phenomenal (Asaṅga); reality is grasped only by prajñā.	Rehabilitated and formalized: a full two-pramāṇa epistemology (perception + inference) able to contest Nyāya on its own ground.
Signature method	Destructive dialectic: catuṣkoṭi applied to every category (causation, motion, self, time, Nirvāṇa, Buddha).	Direct idealist argument: refute realist objections (spatial/temporal determination, intersubjectivity, efficacy) via the dream analogy.	Causal-efficiency criterion + simultaneity/regress dilemmas against every rival permanent principle (Prakṛti, Īśvara, Brahman, Ātman).

Question	Śūnyavāda	Vijñānavāda	Svatantra-Vijñānavāda
Key texts	Mādhyamika-Kārikā, Vigraha-Vyāvarttanī, Ratnāvalī (Nāgārjuna); Prasannapadā (Chandrakīrti); Bodhicharyāvatāra (Śāntideva).	Viṃśatikā, Triṃśikā (Vasubandhu); Mahāyāna-Sūtrālaṅkāra (Asaṅga/Maitreyanātha); Laṅkāvatāra-sūtra.	Pramāṇa-Samuchchaya (Dīnnāga); Pramāṇa-Vārtika (Dharmakīrti); Tattva-saṅgraha (Śāntarakṣita) + Pañjikā (Kamalashīla).
Key figures	Nāgārjuna, Āryadeva, Chandrakīrti, Buddhapālita, Bhāvaviveka, Śāntideva.	Maitreyanātha, Asaṅga, Vasubandhu, Sthiramati.	Dīnnāga, Dharmakīrti, Śāntarakṣita, Kamalashīla.

4.2 What They Agree On (the Shared Core, Restated)

- The empirical/absolute (Samvṛti/Paramārtha) distinction, and the refusal to let one collapse into the other.
- Dharma-nairātmya: not just the personal self but phenomena themselves are without own-being.
- Discursive intellect cannot, unaided, deliver ultimate truth; some form of direct realization (prajñā, yogic practice) is indispensable.
- None of the three schools is nihilistic, whatever their opponents charged — each explicitly retains the reality of the phenomenal at its own level.

4.3 Where They Genuinely Diverge (the Branch Points)

If you need to compress this entire guide into three sentences for an exam: Śūnyavāda tells you what is not real by exhausting every logical possibility for it (the tetralemma) and leaves the positive Absolute under-described. Vijñānavāda supplies the positive description — Consciousness — and a mechanism (the Ālaya, Trisvabhāva) for how appearance works, but rests its case on scriptural/meditative authority more than argument. Svatantra-Vijñānavāda keeps Vijñānavāda's idealism but insists on winning the argument on logic's own terms, and in doing so redefines “the real” away from “permanent Consciousness” and toward “the momentary, causally efficient particular” — a definition in real tension with the very idealism it claims to serve.

PART 5 · Internal Fault Lines — Where Buddhist Philosophers Disagreed With Each Other

These cross-cutting disputes are where the tradition is most alive, and where essay questions tend to concentrate. Each is a place where accepting the shared core (Part 0, Part 4.2) still left real room for disagreement.

5.1 Prāsaṅgika vs. Svātantrika — Can Logic Prove Anything Positive?

Already introduced at §1.6: Chandrakīrti's Prāsaṅgika insists the Mādhyamika has “no thesis” and only exposes opponents' self-contradictions; Bhāvaviveka's Svātantrika thinks Śūnyavāda can and should be established by independent syllogism. The Logical school of Chapter 8 is best read as the Svātantrika impulse, no longer confined to defending Śūnyatā, generalized into an entire epistemological system.

5.2 Chandrakīrti vs. Diṇnāga — Is the Svalakṣaṇa Really Indescribable?

A direct, explicit cross-school confrontation (Ch.6, §VIII). Diṇnāga's Svalakṣaṇa is supposed to be an indescribable, self-conscious (svasaṃvitti) ultimate particular. Chandrakīrti's rebuttal has two prongs: (1) consciousness cannot apprehend itself, any more than a sword's edge can cut itself or a fingertip touch itself — so 'self-consciousness' of the Svalakṣaṇa is incoherent; (2) the Svalakṣaṇa is defined only by contrast with the Sāmānyalakṣaṇa (particular vs. universal) — but anything defined by contrast with something else is, by Śūnyavāda's own standard, relative, hence not truly indescribable or absolute at all. Diṇnāga's logic, on this reading, smuggles back in exactly the kind of relational category his own 'indescribable particular' was supposed to escape.

5.3 Dharmakīrti vs. Śāntarakṣita — Is the Buddha Omniscient?

A genuine, named disagreement within the Logical school itself (Ch.8, §XI). Dharmakīrti, following his own logic to its conclusion, denies omniscience even to the Buddha — reliability requires only true knowledge and compassion, not all-knowing far-sightedness; 'if far-sightedness is the criterion of truth, then let us all adore the vultures.' Śāntarakṣita emphatically disagrees and mounts a full defense of Buddha's omniscience against Mīmāṃsaka objections (absence of perceptual evidence is not proof of non-existence; the Omniscient may be directly self-luminous and self-verifying; the swan's cygnet cannot fly at birth but can cross oceans with practice). This is a clean, citable example of two thinkers sharing an entire technical apparatus (momentariness, causal efficiency, the two pramāṇas) and still reaching opposite conclusions on a major point.

5.4 Laṅkāvatāra's Ālaya vs. Vasubandhu's Ālaya — Permanent or a Stream?

Already tabulated at §2.2 (Table 3): one and the same technical term is used for an eternal Absolute in one text and a changing phenomenal stream in another. Sharma resolves it by placing Vasubandhu's Ālaya one level down from his own Vijñaptimātra — but the terminological collision is real and is a favorite trap in casual summaries of Yogācāra.

5.5 Bhattacharya vs. Sharma — Is Vijñaptimātra 'Nitya' or Merely 'Dhruva'?

A fine-grained philological dispute worth knowing because it shows how much metaphysical weight a single Sanskrit word choice can carry. Vidhushekhara Bhattacharya argued that because Vasubandhu's *Triṃśikā* (K.30) calls *Vijñaptimātra* 'Dhruva' rather than 'Nitya,' it must be only relatively permanent (like a stream), not absolutely eternal. Sharma concedes this reading is correct for the phenomenal *Ālayavijñāna* — but argues Bhattacharya wrongly extends it to *Vijñaptimātra* itself, and cites *Sthiramati*'s own commentary (which glosses 'Dhruva' as 'Nitya,' and explicitly reasons “what is permanent is bliss; what is momentary is misery”) as decisive textual evidence that *Vijñaptimātra* is meant as absolutely eternal.

5.6 Śūnyavāda's Bodhi vs. Vijñānavāda's Vijñaptimātra — Same Absolute?

Sharma explicitly argues (Ch.7, §V.B) that the common claim “Śūnyavāda denies even Consciousness” is false: Śūnyavāda only denies the reality of the individual subject and criticizes self-consciousness in the *Chandrakīrti*/*Diñnāga* sense (§5.2) — but *Nāgārjuna*'s own *Prapañcha-Śūnya Tattva* is explicitly identified with *Bodhi*/*Prajñā*; *Āryadeva*'s *Chitta* and *Śāntideva*'s *Bodhi-Chitta* are, on this reading, the same Self-luminous Self that *Vijñānavāda* calls *Vijñaptimātra*. The two schools' vocabularies (“Emptiness” vs. “Consciousness”) may describe one and the same terminus reached from two different directions — a genuinely unifying thesis, though not one every Śūnyavādin or Vijñānavādin would necessarily accept.

PART 6 · Merged Master Glossary

Terms are cross-referenced by school of primary use: [Ś] Śūnyavāda, [V] Vijñānavāda, [SV] Svatantra-Vijñānavāda, [All] shared across the tradition. Where a term is used differently by different schools, both senses are given.

Abhūtaparikalpa [V] — “Construction of the unreal.” Applied at all three levels of Trisvabhāva: as ground (Pariniṣpanna), as the Ālaya's active self-manifesting energy (Paratantra), and as the superimposed duality itself (Parikalpita).

Ālayavijñāna [V] — “Store-house Consciousness.” In the Laṅkāvatāra: permanent, identical with the Absolute. In Vasubandhu: a changing phenomenal stream containing seeds of all phenomena, one modification below true Vijñaptimātra. See Table 3.

Anutpāda [Ś] — “No-origination.” Nāgārjuna's opening thesis: nothing arises from itself, another, both, or at random — the destructive dialectic's core engine.

Apoha [SV] — Diṇnāga's doctrine that words denote only by negation/exclusion (“cow” = “not-non-cow”); refined by Śāntarākṣita into relative vs. absolute negation.

Catuṣkoṭi [All] — The tetralemma: existence / non-existence / both / neither — the four categories intellect can generate about any predicate; Reality is said to transcend all four.

Dharma-nairātmya [All] — Unreality of all elements/dharmas, not just the personal self — Mahāyāna's advance beyond Hīnayāna's pudgala-nairātmya.

Jñeyāvaraṇa / Kleśāvaraṇa [All] — The two obscurations: the screen of the knowable (intellect reifying objects) and the screen of defilement (passions producing suffering); both must be removed for liberation.

Nissvabhāva [All] — “Devoid of own-nature.” In Vijñānavāda applied to all three svabhāvas but in three distinct senses (§2.3); in Śūnyavāda synonymous with svabhāva-śūnya.

Paramārtha / Saṃvṛti [All] — The Two Truths: absolute standpoint (grasped by prajñā) vs. conventional/empirical standpoint (a practical, ultimately unreal, but indispensable “covering”).

Parikalpita / Paratantra / Pariniṣpanna [V] — Vijñānavāda's three natures: the purely imaginary, the causally dependent/relative, and the absolutely real — refining Śūnyavāda's two truths into three grades (Table 3).

Prajñā-pāramitā [Ś] — Perfect/Supreme Knowledge, the sixth and highest Pāramitā; non-dual, beyond intellect; Reality itself grasped directly.

Pramāṇa [SV, All] — Means of valid cognition. Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā admit several; the Logical school restricts valid pramāṇas to exactly two — perception and inference (§3.5).

Pratītyasamutpāda [All] — Dependent Origination / Relativity — in Śūnyavāda, the empirical sense of Śūnya; in the Logical school, redefined away from “production” toward bare functional succession (§3.3).

Sāmānyalakṣaṇa / Svalakṣaṇa [SV] — The universal/general character (object of inference) vs. the unique momentary particular (object of perception) — the Logical school's central epistemological pair; Chandrakīrti's target at §5.2.

Śūnya [Ś] — Emptiness — carefully NOT “nothing.” Four-part meaning: indescribable, relative, the Real itself, and both relative-and-Real simultaneously (§1.2).

Tathāgatagarbha / Tathatā [All] — Aśvaghoṣa's names for Reality/Suchness, beyond all categories; later identified with Ālayavijñāna (Laṅkāvatāra sense) and treated as the common root of both Śūnyavāda and Vijñānavāda (Part 0).

Trisvabhāva [V] — The “three natures” — Vijñānavāda's refinement of the Two Truths into three ontological grades (§2.3).

Vijñaptimātra [V, SV] — “Consciousness-only” — the school's central metaphysical thesis; per Sharma, truly eternal (Nitya), contra Bhattacharya (§5.5); largely sidelined as a working concept in the Logical school's technical apparatus (§3.1).

PART 7 · One-Page Recall Sheet

If asked “what is real, according to each school?”

- Śūnyavāda: the indescribable Non-dual Absolute, beyond Śūnya and Aśūnya, beyond all four horns of the catuṣkoṭi.
- Vijñānavāda: Pure Consciousness (Vijñaptimātra), permanent and self-luminous; everything else is its modification.
- Svatantra-Vijñānavāda: officially, Pure Consciousness (per Śāntarakṣita); operationally, the momentary causally-efficient particular (Svalakṣaṇa).

If asked “what problem does each school solve for its predecessor?”

- Vijñānavāda solves Śūnyavāda's under-description of the positive Absolute by naming it Consciousness and explaining the mechanics of appearance (Ālaya, Trisvabhāva).
- Svatantra-Vijñānavāda solves Vijñānavāda's lack of independent logical rigor by building a full pramāṇa-theory able to out-argue Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā on their own terms.

If asked for the single best-known internal disagreement in each school

- Śūnyavāda: Prāsaṅgika (Chandrakīrti) vs. Svātantrika (Bhāvaviveka) on whether logic can prove anything positively.
- Vijñānavāda: the Laṅkāvatāra's permanent Ālaya vs. Vasubandhu's phenomenal-stream Ālaya.
- Svatantra-Vijñānavāda: Dharmakīrti (denies Buddha's omniscience) vs. Śāntarakṣita (affirms it).

If asked to define “Śūnya” correctly (the most commonly mis-defined term)

Never “nothing” or “void.” Always: (1) indescribable, beyond all four categories of intellect; (2) relative/dependently-originated, hence not ultimately real but not therefore non-existent; (3) the Real itself, i.e. release from plurality (Nirvāṇa); (4) both (2) and (3) at once.

If asked why none of this counts as nihilism

Because absolute negation presupposes affirmation and is therefore impossible; because the Two Truths structure is retained throughout (the phenomenal is real at its own level); and because each school pairs its critique with a full constructive path (Bodhisattva bhūmis, the four dhyānas, the pramāṇa-based path to Buddhahood) rather than leaving a bare logical vacuum.